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Promoting healthy sleep with the CDC

As the nation's health protection agency, the [Centers for Disease Control and Prevention](#) tackles the biggest health problems in the U.S. One problem on its radar is our lack of sleep.

CDC data show that 30 percent of adults in the U.S. fail to get enough sleep each night. The percentage of sleepless teens is much higher. The problem is so pervasive that the CDC has stated, "[Insufficient sleep is a public health epidemic.](#)"

Why is sleep loss such a big deal? A wealth of research shows that sleep is essential for the health of your brain, heart and body. When sleep is lacking, problems such as heart disease, diabetes, obesity and depression are much more likely to occur. Sleep loss also increases the risk of drowsy driving and workplace accidents.

"Healthy sleep is not a luxury," said [American Academy of Sleep Medicine](#) President Dr. Safwan Badr. "It is a necessity and should be thought of as a vital sign of good health."

Yesterday the AASM announced a new partnership with the CDC to develop the National Healthy Sleep Awareness Project. The five-year project will promote the achievement of the [sleep health objectives in Healthy People 2020](#). Strategic direction for the project will be provided by the CDC, AASM and the Sleep Research Society.

What is healthy sleep? It's a combination of quantity and quality. You may have poor sleep even though you spend seven to eight hours in bed each night. Sleep can be disrupted by factors such as chronic pain, stress or anxiety, and medication side effects.

A sleep illness such as [obstructive sleep apnea](#) also can ruin your sleep. OSA involves repeated breathing pauses during sleep. Left untreated, it increases your risk of having a heart attack or stroke.

It's clear that healthy sleep is a key to personal health as well as public health and safety. This is a message that will be spread far and side through the Healthy Sleep project.

November 14, 2013 | [Healthy Sleep Habits](#)

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